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1 Future discussions

More Kernel Optimizations for SGEMM

We have only scratched the surface of optimizing SGEMM. Other topics:

1. Occupancy
2. Contention
3. Bank Conflicts
4. Vectorized Access/Operations
5. etc. (help me fill out list, refer to SIBOEHM)

Alternative Programming Models and DSLs

In production, writing raw CUDA is rarely worth the effort.

1. Triton: tiling is at the heart of GPU optimization, so that becomes our new atomic unit instead of threads. Thread-level optimizations are optimized by a JIT compiler.
2. CUTLASS, CuTe DSL, Layout Algebra: Manually handling indexing is cumbersome and error-prone. We can compose common patterns with an algebra that can be checked at compile time.

Kernel Fusion and Specialized Kernels

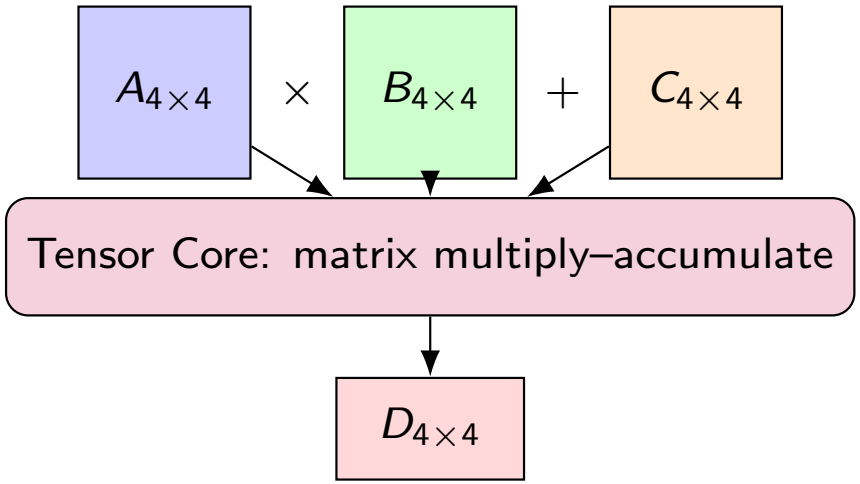
Kernels, be definition, have to read/write from DRAM. We can **fuse** kernels to increase performance.

1. Linear Layer + Nonlinearity = Fused MLP layer
2. FlashAttention series: complex fusion of the Attention Mechanism
3. Megakernels: taken to the extreme, we can fuse the operations necessary for the entire forward pass of a model into a **megakernel.**

Continuing GPU evolution

2017: Volta Tensor Cores

- Tensor Cores perform mixed-precision matrix multiply–accumulate: $D = AB + C$.
- The original Volta unit multiplies FP16 inputs and accumulates in FP16 or FP32.
- Matrix multiplication becomes an explicit hardware primitive, alongside general-purpose CUDA cores.



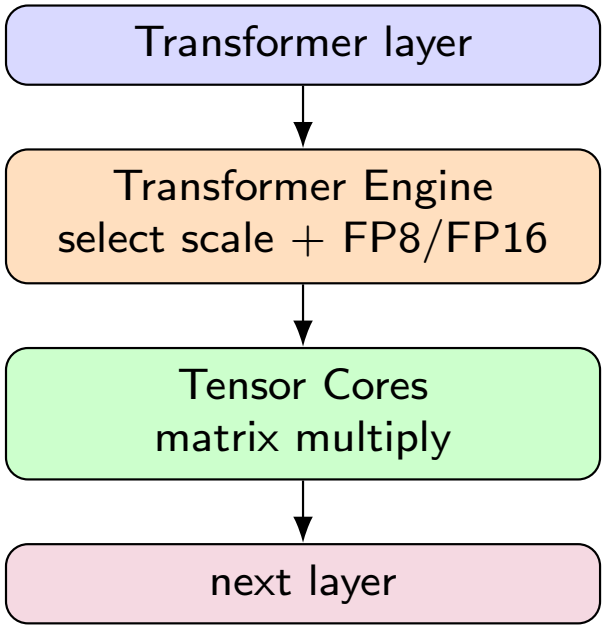
Operation shape shown for first-generation Volta Tensor Cores. Source:

NVIDIA, *Volta Architecture Whitepaper*, 2017.

Continuing GPU evolution

2020 onward: specialize around AI dataflow

- Ampere (2020) adds TF32 and structured sparsity support.
- Hopper (2022) adds FP8 Tensor Cores and a Transformer Engine that dynamically chooses FP8 or FP16 per layer.
- Blackwell (2024) adds more low-precision formats and a second-generation Transformer Engine. This is more than incremental scaling.



Source: NVIDIA, *Hopper Architecture In-Depth* (2022).

Continuing GPU evolution

2026: Vera Rubin, optimizing the rack

- The target is no longer an isolated GPU, but a complete rack-scale computing platform.
- Vera CPUs, Rubin GPUs, memory, NVLink, and networking are designed together to run one distributed AI workload.
- A high-bandwidth scale-up fabric lets many accelerators share model parameters and intermediate results.
- Performance now depends on communication, power, cooling, and software orchestration as well as matrix throughput.

Unit of optimization

Kernel

↓

GPU

↓

Server

↓

Rack-scale system

Source: NVIDIA, *Vera Rubin Architecture*, announced roadmap.

Alternative Accelerator Architectures

Big Picture

With respect to AI accelerators, GPUs are actually remarkably **general**. We can further specialize into AI-specific compute operations.

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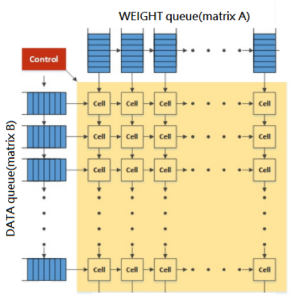
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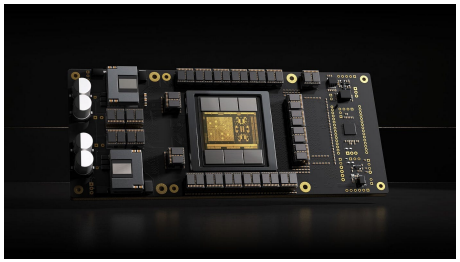
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3. NPUs: Serving AI workloads in power and heat constrained environments (mobile, consumer electronics, edge devices, etc.).
4. WSE (Wafer Scale Engine): Massive data bandwidth through multi-die wafers.

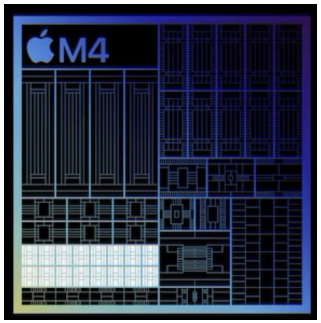
Takeaways



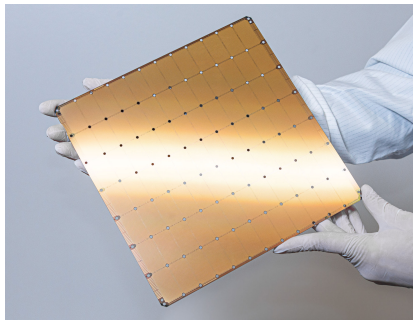
TPU systolic array



Etched Sohu



Apple M4 NPU



Cerebras WSE

There is no universally best architecture

Everything is a tradeoff. Optimizing for something always comes with a cost. **Workflow demands shape hardware evolution.**.